Quadreria
STUDIO

Understanding Your Costing

(WHERE YOUR MONEY ACTUALLY GOES)

A SHORT GUIDE FOR FOUNDERS PLANNING THEIR FIRST PRODUCTION BUDGET.

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Understanding Your Costing

One of the first questions we hear on a discovery call is, "How much will my collection cost?" It's a fair question, and the honest answer is that it depends on more things than most founders expect. The garment itself is only one part of the bill. Everything around it adds up quietly, and that's usually where budgets fall apart.

We'd rather founders hear this before they start spending than halfway through. A realistic budget doesn't hold you back. It's what lets you make confident decisions at every stage instead of panicking at the last one.

So here's how costing actually works.

01 Know every stage that costs money.

Building a collection has several cost stages, not one: design and development, sampling, production, trims (labels, buttons, zips, tags), packaging, and logistics. Founders often budget for production and forget the rest. List every stage from the start, even the small ones, because the small ones add up fastest.

02 Understand why a sample costs more than a production piece.

A sample is made one at a time. The pattern is cut fresh, the machine is set up for a single piece, and someone is working out the construction as they go. In production, those setup costs are spread across hundreds of pieces. So don't judge your production price by your sample price, and don't be alarmed that sampling feels expensive. It's supposed to.

03 See how MOQ shapes your per-unit cost.

MOQ (minimum order quantity) is the smallest order a fabric vendor or manufacturer will accept. Lower quantities usually mean a higher price per piece, because fixed costs are shared across fewer units. Before you decide how many pieces to produce, ask for prices at two or three quantity levels, so you can see where the per-unit cost becomes workable for your margins.

04 Plan for the costs founders often miss.

The usual surprises are extra sampling rounds, screen or setup charges for prints, digitising charges for embroidery, fabric wastage during cutting, and shipping both ways for samples. None of them are huge alone. Together, they can stretch a budget well past what was planned.

05 Budget for the whole journey, not just the garment.

Your money needs to carry you from the first design to the moment the product is in your customer's hands. We always suggest keeping a buffer of around 10–15% for anything unexpected. If you don't need it, it becomes your marketing budget.

A sample cost breakdown for one garment

For illustration only. Actual shares vary by category, fabric, quantity and manufacturer.

Cost Element	Approx. share of per-unit cost
Fabric	40–55%
Cutting, making and finishing	20–30%
Trims and labels	5–10%
Print or embroidery	5–15%
Packaging	3–5%
Logistics	5–10%

When founders understand their costing, conversations with manufacturers become clearer and decisions become faster. If you'd like help planning a budget that fits your collection, that's something we work through with every founder we partner with.

Reach out at: hello@quadreria.studio